Jingyao Wei

PhD Candidate in Economics, Norwegian School of Economics (NHH)

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Citizenship: Chinese

Education

PhD in Economics, Norwegian School of Economics 2022–Present

Expected completion: August 2026

Visiting Scholar, Cornell University (host: Heather Schofield) Spring 2026

MSc in Economics, Norwegian School of Economics 2020–2022

MA in Economics of Education, Central China Normal University 2017–2020

Exchange: National Taiwan University of Science and Technology Spring 2019

BSc in Finance, Hubei University of Economics 2010–2014

Dual-degree program: Auburn University at Montgomery, USA 2013–2014

Research Fields

Development Economics; Environmental Economics; Health Economics

Publications

Psychological Barriers to Participation in the Labor Market: Evidence from Rural Ghana
With Leandro Carvalho, Damien de Walque, Crick Lund, Heather Schofield, and Vincent Somville.
Journal of Development Economics, **181** (2026), 103734.

Abstract: Mental health conditions are strongly associated with lower labor market participation, but the underlying channels remain unclear. We conduct a two-phase study of women in rural Ghana to examine job take-up and work outcomes. In the first phase, we ask whether women would accept cash-for-work jobs during the lean season. Women with depression or anxiety are much more likely to decline work outside the home, but equally likely to accept work-from-home positions. In the second phase, we randomly offer home-based jobs to women willing to work from home. Neither depression nor anxiety predicts work completion, earnings, or quit rates. These findings suggest that barriers to accepting work outside the home help explain the association between mental health and labor market participation, and highlight home-based employment as a potential response.

Working Papers

Solar Poverty Alleviation and the Green-versus-Green Trade-off

Abstract: Solar investment can affect local environments beyond the land occupied by panels. I focus on whether directing solar revenues to poor communities moderates those consequences. As motivation, I document that forest loss rises near solar installations in China, with larger increases in poorer areas. I study China's Solar Energy Poverty Alleviation Program, which assigned benefits from grid-connected solar projects to poor households and villages. Combining the program registry, satellite forest-loss data, and a national household panel, I find that forest loss near program host villages declines by 0.62 hectares per cell-year. Households shift from firewood to electricity for cooking, and electricity spending does not rise as it does in other poverty counties. The probability of respiratory illness among children declines by 10.8 percentage points, while other common illnesses show no change, consistent with reduced exposure to indoor smoke from the household energy transition. These findings suggest that directing renewable energy investment to benefit local households can shape its local environmental and health consequences.

Working Papers (continued)

Heat, Economic Stress, and Mental Health: Evidence from Indonesia
With Simon Taye, Damien de Walque, Heather Schofield, and Hao Wang. *Revise and Resubmit at Frontier Behavior Economics and Mental Health*
Abstract: Evidence on the relationship between heat and mental health varies across populations. We examine whether underlying economic stress explains this heterogeneity using panel data from Indonesia and three types of economic shocks: income losses driven by international palm oil price changes, sudden large increases in fuel costs, and job loss. In the general population, we find no association between temperature and depressive symptoms, measured using the CES-D scale, and can rule out even small harmful effects. Among those experiencing negative economic shocks, however, heat is associated with increases in depressive symptoms of 0.044–0.09 standard deviations per degree Celsius. As climate change increases both the frequency of extreme heat and the prevalence of economic shocks, our findings suggest that the psychological toll of a warming climate will be concentrated among the most economically vulnerable.

Work in Progress

The Causal Effects of Income Volatility and Income Risk
With Leandro Carvalho, Damien de Walque, Nicolas Grandstaff,
Heather Schofield, and Vincent Somville.

Teaching Experience

Teaching Assistant, Norwegian School of Economics

Environmental Policy Analysis	2025
Development Economics	2024
Diversity in Firms	2024
Petroleum Economics	2023
Econometrics	2022

Presentations

European Association of Environmental and Resource Economists (EAERE), Bergen	2025
Nordic Conference in Development Economics, Gothenburg	2023

References

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